

Assignment 2

Introduction to Linguistics 2

Yashaswi Priya – 2025114007

Question 1:

Part I:

a. English:

1. Queer:

Homonymous:

- a. Strange, or odd
- b. Denoting or relating to a sexual or gender identity that does not correspond to established ideas of sexuality and gender, especially heterosexual norms.
The two meanings now co-exist in separate semantic domains and can hence be called Homonyms.
 - a. There was a queer noise coming from the attic.
 - b. The queer community was outraged by the recent political developments.

Polysemous:

Originally, the word queer referred to something strange and uncommon. Due to this meaning, it became a slur used against those with ‘uncommon’ sexual preferences, primarily used for gay men. It was later reclaimed by those who had a non-heteronormative identity.

Hence, as the two meanings of Queer were historically connected, they may be considered polysemous.

2. Ring:

Homonymous:

- a. A raised, square platform surrounded by ropes; where boxing matches occur.
- b. A small, circular metal band, often set with precious stones, worn on a finger as an ornament, or for a symbolic purpose.
The two-meanings aren’t linked anymore and can hence be considered homonymous.
 - a. The crowd cheered as the players descended into the ring.
 - b. The bride’s smile flashed brighter than her ring.

Polysemous:

Historically, boxing was underground or in taverns, where the arena was formed by spectators standing in a circle around the competitors.

As it was a circular area, it retained the name 'ring' despite a change in its shape.

The ring (ornament) has an enclosed, circular shape; and hence received its name.

Hence, as the two meanings of Ring share a common historic root, they can be considered polysemous.

3. Gay:

Homonymous:

- a. Light-hearted and carefree.
- b. Sexually or romantically attracted to someone of their own sex (used primarily for men).

The two meanings are no longer connected and can hence be called homonyms.

- a. The seagulls squawked prettily in the blue sky, on what would prove to be a gay morning.
- b. The gay couple next door has just adopted the most adorable puppy.

Polysemous:

The word Gay was initially used to describe something lively, joyful and light-hearted.

However, it later became pejoratively associated with 'sexual-looseness' (used for those whose sexual preferences lay outside societal norms). It was later reclaimed by those (primarily men) who were attracted to the same sex.

Hence, as the two meanings of Gay were historically connected, they may be considered polysemous.

4. Bright:

Homonymous:

- a. Giving out or reflecting much light; shining.
- b. Intelligent and quick-witted.

The two meanings are no longer connected and can hence be called homonyms.

- a. The room was too bright to see in.
- b. He was a bright, young man and his instructors loved him.

Polysemous:

The word Light started being used as a metaphor for 'enlightenment' and intelligence instead of physical light. Hence, as the two meanings of Bright share a common historic root, they can be considered polysemous.

5. Bank:

Homonymous:

- a. The land alongside or sloping down to a river or lake.
- b. A licensed financial institution that acts as an intermediary by accepting deposits from the public, safeguarding funds, and granting loans to individuals and businesses.
The two meanings are no longer connected and can hence be called homonyms.
 - a. We were all so glad when the bank finally approved her loan request.
 - b. The river had flooded, and its bank was now muddy and slippery.

Polysemous:

The word Bank could have started being used to refer to a something that protects what's kept inside it, forming a boundary of sorts. Hence, a river bank (preventing the river from flooding) is polysemous to a financial institution (protecting money and assets).

b. Hindi:

1. पत्र:

Homonymous:

- a. Letter or loose sheets of paper
- b. Leaf (from the Sanskrit पत्रम्)
The two meanings are no longer connected and can hence be called homonyms.
 - a. हमने पत्रों और पुष्पों की माला पिरोई
 - b. मैंने उसका पत्र पढ़ा

Polysemous:

The word पत्रम् or leaf in Sanskrit, morphed into the पत्र we know today. As palm leaves were also used for writing, it's possible that the word was hence used for loose leaves of paper.

2. निशाचर:

Homonymous:

- a. A nocturnal animal.
- b. A rakshasa or demon.
The two meanings are no longer connected and can hence be called homonyms.
 - a. बाघ एक निशाचर पक्षी है

- b. निशाचरों का भय इन ऋषियों में नहीं था

Polysemous:

The word निशाचर was meant for those that roam around at night (Nisha + aachran) and the word was then adopted for demons and monsters that roam at night.

3. चतुर्भुज:

Homonymous:

- a. A four-sided polygon
- b. Someone with four hands, usually referring to Vishnu.

The two-meanings aren't linked anymore and can hence be considered homonymous.

- a. यह मेज चतुर्भुज के आकार का है
- b. चतुर्भुज भगवान विष्णु जगत के पालनहार हैं

Polysemous:

The word चतुर्भुज originally meant something with four edges (arms) and was then used to signify the literal four arms of God.

4. आँख:

Homonymous:

- a. Eye
- b. A hole or loop

The two meanings are no longer connected and can hence be called homonyms.

- a. उसकी आँखों की गहराइयों में डूब जाने का मन करता है
- b. सुई की आँख में धागा डालने के लिए बहुत समय लगता है

Polysemous:

The word आँख started with referring to the eye, and was then used for other objects of a similar shape.

5. धारा:

Homonymous:

- a. Stream of a liquid such as water or milk.
- b. Section of the law.

The two meanings now co-exist in separate semantic domains and can hence be called Homonyms.

- a. पुलिस का यह कानूनी कर्तव्य है कि वे गिरफ्तार व्यक्ति को उनकी गिरफ्तारी की धारा के बारे में सूचित करें
- b. दूध की पतली धारा बह रही थी

Polysemous:

Originally, the word धारा referred to the stream of a liquid. Because of the metaphorical flow of the law and its organized nature, धारा might have been used to refer to different sections of the law code.

Part II:

1. Metonymy:

Metonymy refers to a literary device that replaces the name of an entity with the name of something else closely associated with it. Like:

पत्र-> A loose, small, thin sheet. Hence, the content of a letter is referred to by the same name as the sheet of paper (which was historically made of palm leaves and hence has the same name as a leaf.)

2. Semantic Specialization:

This is a type of linguistic development where the meaning of a word becomes more specific, specialized, or less general over time.

पति -> earlier it referred to a protector. So सेनापति was the protector of the armed forces (सेना). Later on, the meaning was specialized to mean husband.

3. Metaphor:

A figure of speech in which a word or phrase is applied to an object or action to which it is not literally applicable.

Queer -> used a metaphor for the LGBT+ community as they have a sexual or gender identity that does not correspond to established heterosexual norms.

Question 2:

Part I:

Words allow co-prediction, when they are used in such a manner where both the meanings of the word in a sentence are systematically related, not just accidentally.

The inhabitants of a city, and the fact that it outlawed smoking, are related; as the city as an administrative organization, and as a town, have closely related interpretations.

On the other hand, a piece of paper and an organization are loosely related. Hence, the word newspaper cannot be used for the same.

Also, if the two interpretations of the word are closely related (polysemy) and not completely isolated (homonyms), then such words allow co-prediction.

Yes, this does seem to be a consistent trend throughout languages.

1. विद्यालय:

1945 में स्थापित हुए विद्यालय ने नयी नीति लागु की।

Here, Vidyalaya is used to refer to the physical school, as well as its board of administration.

2. अदालत:

पुरानी दिल्ली में स्थित अदालत, फैसला सुना रही है।

Here, अदालत refers to both the physical location of the court, and its legislative authority.

Part II:

If the two interpretations of the word are closely related (polysemous) and aren't completely isolated (homonymous), then such words allow co-prediction.

Polysemous words hence allow co-prediction more freely.

Eg:

Due to its polluted air, New Delhi announced a new policy yesterday.

Here, New Delhi refers to both the city, and its government. This is a polysemous example as New Delhi is the capital of the country, and is hence used to refer to the Government of India.

Homonymy doesn't allow for frequent co-prediction. This is because the different meanings of the words aren't very closely related.

Eg.:

The bank was flooded and refused to grant a loan.

This is hence NOT a proper sentence.

